

Skill assessment

Evaluative surveys for establishing management skills

Tip: These surveys at the beginning of each chapter in the book are designed to maximise your learning and the development of your management skills. Some of the questions are probing and personal. Thoughtful, accurate and honest answers will increase your learning and development.

How ethical are you?

Given how critical management ethics has become, we commence the book with an ethics skill assessment.

Complete the answers to this survey. The survey is difficult to answer because it goes to the heart of our subtle internal thoughts and reactions. Be very honest and thoughtful about these questions. When answering, consider your internal response and your unspoken thoughts and feelings, rather than your intentions or behaviour.

Rating scale

- 1 Almost never
- 2 Rarely
- 3 Sometimes
- 4 Mostly
- 5 Almost always

- | | |
|----------|--|
| <u>4</u> | 1. I tend to react to people according to their appearance. |
| <u>3</u> | 2. I feel a little uncomfortable if the person I am speaking to is too tall (short, fat, young, strongly accented, hesitant, and so on). |
| <u>3</u> | 3. I prefer to speak to people who have similar interests to me in sport, politics and the arts. |
| <u>2</u> | 4. I tend to avoid people in the organisation who seem a bit on the outer. |
| <u>4</u> | 5. On a selection panel I tend to favour an applicant I feel comfortable with. |
| <u>3</u> | 6. An unresolved argument with a colleague in the past would get in the way of me offering them a new work opportunity. |
| <u>2</u> | 7. I believe that my contribution in a workgroup is more significant than others really appreciate. |
| <u>2</u> | 8. I tend to work harder and more skilfully than most of my colleagues. |

Scoring keys for each of these surveys are found at the end of the chapter, beginning on page 43.

In relation to the ethics survey, you may also wish to access the Implicit Association Test (IAT) developed by Tony Greenwald, Professor of Psychology, University of Washington, at <www.buster.cs.yale.edu/implicit> or <www.tolerance.org/hidden_bias/index.html>.

Personal assessment of management skills

Step 1: To get an overall profile of your level of skill competence, respond to the following statements using the rating scale below. Please rate your behaviour as it is, not as you would like it to be. If you have not engaged in a certain activity, answer according to how you think you would behave, based on your experience in similar activities. Be realistic; this instrument is designed to help you tailor your learning to your specific needs. After you have completed the survey, the scoring key at the end of the chapter (page 43) will help you to generate an overall profile of your management skill strengths and weaknesses.

Step 2: Use copies of the associates' version of this instrument. An alternative version has been provided on page 44 that uses 'he or she' instead of 'I' in the questions. Give copies to at least three people who know you well or who have observed you in a managerial situation. They should complete the instrument by rating your behaviour. Bring the completed surveys back to class and compare your own ratings to your associates' ratings, your associates' ratings to the ratings received by others in the class, and the ratings you received to those of a national norm group.

Subsections of this instrument appear in each chapter throughout the book.

Rating scale

- 1 Strongly disagree
- 2 Disagree
- 3 Slightly disagree
- 4 Slightly agree
- 5 Agree
- 6 Strongly agree

In regard to my level of self-knowledge:

- 5 1. I seek information about my strengths and weaknesses from others as a basis for self-improvement.
- 4 2. In order to improve, I am willing to share my beliefs and feelings with others.
- 5 3. I am very much aware of my preferred style in gathering information and making decisions.
- 4 4. I have a good sense of how I cope with situations that are ambiguous and uncertain.
- 5 5. I have a well-developed set of personal standards and principles that guide my behaviour.

When faced with stressful or time-pressured situations:

- 4 6. I use effective time-management methods such as keeping track of my time, making to-do lists and setting task priorities.
- 4 7. I frequently confirm my priorities so that less important things do not drive out more important things.
- 3 8. I maintain a program of regular exercise for fitness.
- 4 9. I maintain an open, trusting relationship with someone with whom I can share my frustrations.
- 3 10. I know and practise several temporary relaxation techniques such as deep breathing and muscle relaxation.
- 4 11. I strive to redefine problems as opportunities for improvement.

When I approach a typical, routine problem:

- 5 12. I always define clearly and explicitly what the problem is.
- 4 13. I always generate more than one alternative solution to the problem.
- 4 14. I keep problem-solving steps distinct; that is, I make sure that the processes of formulating definitions, generating alternatives and finding solutions are separated.

When faced with a complex or difficult problem that does not have a straightforward solution:

- 4 15. I try to be flexible in the way I approach the problem; I do not just rely on conventional wisdom or past practice.
- 4 16. I try to unfreeze my thinking by asking lots of questions about the nature of the problem.
- 3 17. I frequently use metaphors or analogies to help me analyse the problem and discover what else it is like.

PART 1 • PERSONAL SKILLS

- 5 18. I strive to look at problems from different perspectives so as to generate multiple definitions.
- 4 19. I do not evaluate the merits of each alternative solution to the problem until I have generated many alternatives.

When trying to foster more creativity and innovation among those with whom I work:

- 5 20. I make sure there are divergent points of view represented in every problem-solving group.
- 4 21. I try to acquire information from customers regarding their preferences and expectations.
- 5 22. I provide recognition not only to those who are idea champions but also to those who support others' ideas and who provide resources to implement them.
- 3 23. I encourage informed rule breaking in pursuit of creative solutions.

In situations where I have to provide negative feedback or offer corrective advice:

- 4 24. I help others recognise and define their own problems when I counsel them.
- 4 25. I understand clearly when it is appropriate to offer advice and direction to others and when it is not.
- 5 26. I always give feedback that is focused on problems and solutions, not on personal characteristics.
- 4 27. My feedback is always specific and to the point, rather than general or vague.
- 4 28. I am descriptive in giving negative feedback to others—that is, I objectively describe events, their consequences and my feelings about them.
- 5 29. I take responsibility for my statements and point of view by using, for example, 'I have decided' instead of 'They have decided'.
- 4 30. I convey flexibility and openness to conflicting opinions when presenting my point of view, even when I feel strongly about it.
- 5 31. I do not talk down to those who have less power or less information than I.
- 4 32. I do not dominate conversations with others.

In a situation where it is important to obtain more power:

- 5 33. I always put forth more effort and take more initiative than expected in my work.
- 5 34. I am continually upgrading my skills and knowledge.
- 3 35. I strongly support organisational ceremonial events and activities.
- 4 36. I form a broad network of relationships with people at all levels throughout the organisation.
- 4 37. In my work I consistently strive to generate new ideas, initiate new activities and minimise routine tasks.
- 4 38. I consistently send personal notes to others when they accomplish something significant or when I pass along important information to them.
- 5 39. I refuse to bargain with individuals who use high-pressure negotiation tactics.
- 5 40. I always avoid using threats or demands to impose my will on others.

When another person needs to be motivated:

- 5 41. I always determine if the person has the necessary resources and support to succeed in a task.
- 4 42. I use a variety of rewards to reinforce exceptional performances.
- 4 43. I design task assignments to make them interesting and challenging.
- 4 44. I make sure that the person gets timely feedback from those affected by task performance.
- 4 45. I always help the person establish performance goals that are challenging, specific and time-bound.
- 5 46. Only as a last resort do I attempt to reassign or release a poorly performing individual.

47. I consistently discipline when effort is below expectations and capabilities.
48. I make sure that people feel fairly and equitably treated.
49. I provide immediate compliments and other forms of recognition for meaningful accomplishments.

When I see someone doing something that needs correcting:

50. I avoid making personal accusations and attributing self-serving motives to the other person.
51. I encourage two-way interaction by inviting the respondent to express his or her perspective and to ask questions.
52. I make a specific request, detailing a more acceptable option.

When someone complains about something I have done:

53. I show genuine concern and interest, even when I disagree.
54. I seek additional information by asking questions that provide specific and descriptive information.
55. I ask the other person to suggest more acceptable behaviours.

When two people are in conflict and I am the mediator:

56. I do not take sides but remain neutral.
57. I help the parties generate multiple alternatives.
58. I help the parties find areas on which they agree.

In situations where I have an opportunity to empower others:

59. I help people feel competent in their work by recognising and celebrating their small successes.
60. I provide regular feedback and needed support.
61. I try to provide all the information that people need to accomplish their tasks.
62. I exhibit caring and personal concern for each person with whom I have dealings.

When delegating work to others:

63. I specify clearly the results I desire.
64. I specify clearly the level of initiative I want others to take (for example, wait for directions, do part of the task and then report, do the whole task and then report, and so forth).
65. I allow participation by those accepting assignments regarding when and how the work will be done.
66. I avoid upward delegation by asking people to recommend solutions, rather than merely asking for advice or answers when a problem is encountered.
67. I follow up and maintain accountability for delegated tasks on a regular basis.

When I am attempting to build and lead an effective team:

68. I help team members establish a foundation of trust among one another and between themselves and me.
69. I help members learn to play roles that assist the team in accomplishing its tasks as well as building strong interpersonal relationships.
70. I encourage a win-win philosophy in the team—that is, when one member wins, every member wins.
71. I encourage the team to achieve dramatic breakthrough innovations as well as small continuous improvements.
72. I manage difficult team members effectively, through supportive communication, collaborative conflict management and empowerment.

- _____ 1. People at all levels are encouraged and supported to speak openly and honestly about what they think.
- _____ 2. There is genuine conversation—managers listen to what people say.
- _____ 3. Many people are encouraged to take the lead and express their ideas and visions, and managers are responsive to these new ideas.
- _____ 4. Values, goals and actions are determined and shared by people at all levels of the organisation.
- _____ 5. Each manager is a reflection and example of the vision, mission and values shared by people at all levels in the organisation.
- _____ 6. Managers are genuinely committed to learning and building their expertise.
- _____ 7. People at all levels are acknowledged and valued as individual members and contributors.
- _____ 8. People's plans and actions within the organisation are motivated by their common values and shared vision.
- _____ 9. The organisation succeeds primarily because of the vision and empowerment of people at all levels.
- _____ 10. People at all levels understand their key responsibilities. People are encouraged to think for themselves and take responsible action based on what they understand to be important for the organisation's success.
- _____ 11. As long as their intentions and actions are mostly in the right direction, people are allowed to make mistakes. Mistakes are considered important feedback for how to improve, and people are prepared to try something and then assess its effectiveness.
- _____ 12. People's plans and actions within the organisation are primarily motivated by their alignment with common values and passion to reach a shared vision.

Source: Adapted from A. Deering, R. Dilts and J. Russell, 'Leadership cults and cultures', *Leader to Leader*, 28, Spring 2003, pp. 36–43.

Management communication skills

Answer the following questions:

Rating scale

- 1 None of the time
- 2 Some of the time
- 3 A lot of the time
- 4 All the time

- 3 1. I watch people closely when I talk with them.
- 3 2. I put a lot of energy into my communication.
- 4 3. I think about the best way to make myself understood.
- 3 4. I pay attention to the speed of the person's communication.
- 3 5. I get a sense of the other person before raising my proposition.
- 3 6. I use some of the way they see the world in my communication with them.
- 4 7. I plan what I want to say before my meeting.
- 4 8. I plan the way I want to present my communication before the meeting.
- 3 9. I consciously adjust my presentation style according to the nature of the other person's communication.
- 2 10. I am comfortable with silence during my discussions.
- 3 11. I feel good about myself when I am talking with others.
- 3 12. I attempt to give the other person a sense of their worth when I talk to them.
- 4 13. I am curious about the other person's presentation.
- 3 14. I am patient in my communication.
- 3 15. Later on, I reflect back positively on my communications.

Skill assessment

Evaluative surveys for self-awareness

Self-awareness assessment

Step 1: Before you read the material in this chapter, respond to the following statements by writing a number from the rating scale below in the left-hand column (pre-assessment). Your answers should reflect your attitudes and behaviour as they are now, not as you would like them to be. Be honest. This instrument is designed to help you discover how self-aware you are so that you can tailor your learning to your specific needs. When you have completed the survey, use the scoring key at the end of the chapter to identify the skill areas discussed in this chapter that are most important for you to master.

Step 2: When you have completed the reading and the exercises in this chapter and, ideally, as many of the skill application assignments at the end of the chapter as you can, cover up your first set of answers. Then respond to the same statements again, this time in the right-hand column (post-assessment). When you have completed the survey, use the scoring key at the end of the chapter to measure your progress. If your score remains low in specific skill areas, use the behavioural guidelines at the end of the skill-learning section to guide further practice.

Rating scale

- 1 Strongly disagree
- 2 Disagree
- 3 Slightly disagree
- 4 Slightly agree
- 5 Agree
- 6 Strongly agree

Assessment

Pre-	Post-	
<u>5</u>	_____	1. I seek information about my strengths and weaknesses from others as a basis for self-improvement.
<u>4</u>	_____	2. When I receive negative feedback about myself from others, I do not get angry or defensive.
<u>4</u>	_____	3. In order to improve, I am willing to be self-disclosing to others (that is, to share my beliefs and feelings).
<u>5</u>	_____	4. I am very much aware of my personal style of gathering information and making decisions.
<u>4</u>	_____	5. I am very much aware of my own interpersonal needs when it comes to forming relationships with other people.
<u>4</u>	_____	6. I have a good sense of how I cope with situations that are ambiguous and uncertain.
<u>5</u>	_____	7. I have a well-developed set of personal standards and principles that guide my behaviour.
<u>4</u>	_____	8. I feel very much in charge of what happens to me, good and bad.
<u>3</u>	_____	9. I seldom, if ever, feel angry, depressed or anxious without knowing why.
<u>4</u>	_____	10. I am conscious of the areas in which conflict and friction most frequently arise in my interactions with others.
<u>5</u>	_____	11. I have a close personal relationship with at least one other person with whom I can share personal information and personal feelings.

The scoring key is on page 112.

Leadership Enhancement Team Style (LETS)

The Leadership Enhancement Team Style (LETS) (Andrewartha 2011) is a means of understanding your unique team leadership and communication style. The theory and practice are outlined in subsequent sections of this chapter. Your responses to the questionnaire will help you to identify your individual managerial behaviour as described in the text.

Step 1: To obtain your LETS profile, go online to <www.mcpheeandrewartha.com.au>.

Step 2: Click on the 'Developing management skills ed 5' logo on the home page.

Step 3: Click on the 'Questionnaire' logo.

Step 4: Enter username DMS5 and password ed5 and answer each of the statements as directed.

Step 5: Click 'Submit Answers' and your unique one-page profile will appear for you to print out.

Step 6: Use this profile against the text beginning on page 77 to understand your team leadership style and your matching behaviours in relation to other people.

A guide to interpretation of the LETS data from over 4000 managers is found on page 113.

If you have any problems with the online process, contact 61 8 8357 1800 or send an email to people@mcpheeandrewartha.com.au.

Emotional intelligence assessment

Finish each statement below by selecting the one alternative that is most likely to be your response. Think about the way you usually respond to these kinds of situations, not the way you would like to respond or the way you think you should respond. No correct answers exist for any of the items, and your scores will be most useful if you provide an accurate assessment of your typical behaviour. Mark only one answer per item.

1. When I get really upset, I ...
 - ☒ a. Analyse why I am so disturbed.
 - b. Blow up and let off steam.
 - c. Hide it and remain calm.
2. In a situation in which a colleague takes credit in public for my work and my ideas, I would probably ...
 - a. Let it slide and do nothing, in order to avoid a confrontation.
 - b. Later, in private, indicate that I would appreciate being given credit for my work and ideas.
 - ☒ c. Thank the person in public for referencing my work and ideas, and then elaborate on my contributions.
3. When I approach another person and try to strike up a conversation but the other person does not respond, I ...
 - a. Try to cheer up the person by sharing a funny story.
 - ☒ b. Ask the person if he or she wants to talk about what is on his or her mind.
 - c. Leave the person alone and find someone else to talk to.
4. When I enter a social group, I usually ...
 - a. Remain quiet and wait for people to talk to me.
 - ☒ b. Try to find something complimentary I can tell someone.
 - c. Find ways to be the life of the party or the source of energy and fun.
5. On important issues, I usually ...
 - a. Make up my own mind and ignore others' opinions.
 - ☒ b. Weigh both sides, and discuss it with others before making a decision.
 - c. Listen to my friends or colleagues and make the same decision they do.
6. When someone that I do not particularly like becomes romantically attracted to me, I usually ...
 - a. Tell that person directly that I am not interested.
 - ☒ b. Respond by being friendly but cool or aloof.
 - c. Ignore the person and try to avoid him or her.

7. When I am in the company of two people who have diametrically opposing points of view about an issue (for example, politics, abortion, war) and are arguing about it, I ...
 - ☒ a. Find something about which they can both agree and emphasise it.
 - b. Encourage the verbal battle.
 - c. Suggest that they stop arguing and calm down.
8. When I am playing a sport and the game comes down to my last-second performance, I ...
 - a. Get very nervous and hope that I do not choke.
 - b. See this as an opportunity to shine.
 - ☒ c. Stay focused and give it my best effort.
9. In a situation in which I have an important obligation and need to leave work early, but my colleagues ask me to stay to meet a deadline, I would probably ...
 - ☒ a. Cancel my obligation and stay to complete the deadline.
 - b. Exaggerate a bit by telling my colleagues that I have an emergency that I cannot miss.
 - c. Require some kind of compensation for missing the obligation.
10. In a situation in which another person becomes very angry and begins yelling at me, I ...
 - a. Get angry in return. I do not take that from anyone.
 - b. Walk away. It does not do any good to argue.
 - ☒ c. Listen first, and then try to discuss the issue.
11. When I encounter someone who has just experienced a major loss or tragedy, I ...
 - a. Really do not know what to do or say.
 - ☒ b. Tell the person I feel very sorry and try to provide support.
 - c. Share a time when I experienced a similar loss or tragedy.
12. When someone makes a racist joke or tells a crude story about a member of the opposite sex in mixed company, I usually ...
 - ☒ a. Point out that this is inappropriate and not acceptable, and then change the subject.
 - b. Ignore it so I do not cause a scene.
 - c. Get really upset and tell the person just what I think of what was said.

The scoring key is on page 115.

The Defining Issues Test

This instrument assesses your opinions about controversial social issues. Different people make decisions about these issues in different ways. You should answer the questions for yourself without discussing them with others. You are presented with three stories. Following each story are 12 statements or questions. Your task after reading the story is to rate each statement in terms of its importance in making a decision. After rating each statement, select the four most important statements and rank them from one to four in the spaces provided. Each statement should be ranked in terms of its relative importance in making a decision.

Some statements will raise important issues, but you should ask yourself whether the decision should rest on that issue. Some statements sound high and lofty but are largely gibberish. If you cannot make sense of a statement, or if you do not understand its meaning, mark it 5—‘Of no importance’.

For information about interpreting and scoring the Defining Issues Test, refer to the scoring key at the end of the chapter. Use the following rating scale for your response.

Rating scale

- | | | |
|---|----------------------|--|
| 1 | Of great importance | This statement or question makes a crucial difference in making a decision about the problem. |
| 2 | Of much importance | This statement or question is something that would be a major factor (though not always a crucial one) in making a decision. |
| 3 | Of some importance | This statement or question involves something you care about, but it is not of great importance in reaching a decision. |
| 4 | Of little importance | This statement or question is not very important to consider in this case. |